



Negative scanners can scan images directly from film negative into high-quality images



Nikon launches the P90
— a 12.1 MP camera with a 24x optical zoom

TRIED & TESTED

It has been years now since point-and-shoots (P&S) were developed, and the pace at which developments and improvements have taken place has been staggering. Within a decade, we've gone from film cameras that couldn't guarantee a proper set of photos in a film to digital point-and-shoots that can detect faces, store them, click photos when people smile and there's hardly any cost involved in using them!

What else could anyone want? There are those who look at point-and-shoots and think of them as toys and consider the only proper cameras to be the dSLRs. Speaking practically, point-and-shoots are actually pretty decent. Prosumer P&Ss, such as the Sony DSC H5, the Canon SX 10 IS, the Canon PowerShot S5 IS and many more, have closed the gap between standard point-and-shoots and dSLRs. Easy operation, and the ability to take macro photos to telephoto shots on a single camera without the need for changing any lens or settings. For hassle-free photographs, these prosumer cameras are very good.

However, if you are serious about photography and are analytical about quality and perfection, then we and other enthusiasts will tell you that you ought to buy a dSLR. If you are a professional photographer using a P&S camera, then we honestly aren't sure why...

dSLRs bring a lot to the table, and there are good reasons for their weight, size and the number of knobs and settings they carry. You don't just go out and buy a dSLR and walk around with it in your pocket. They require a rather more considered approach. They are meant for those who'll sit an entire weekend in a nursery taking photos of flowers, go out and do some wild life photography, sports photography and

will take that kind of dedicated time on the camera trying out all kinds of shots. dSLRs are modular gadgets. So over time, you'll be drawn into buying an extra lens or two. The type you buy and the amount you spend will obviously depend on your requirements.

The Contenders

For the dSLR test, we were looking at entry-level and prosumer dSLRs. These are cameras which existing P&S users would perhaps opt for in their second step into photography. We received cameras from Canon and Nikon, the giants with a history in dSLRs. Sony, a newcomer to the dSLR market also sent us its entry-level A200. Sony having bought out Konica-Minolta's dSLR business, this would be one camera not to be taken lightly. The Canon EOS 1000D and the EOS 50D were with us for the test and we also got our hands on the EOS 400D.

Canon EOS 400D

Canon's EOS 400D is a slightly older camera than the rest. It followed the EOS 350D and is well known as a cheaper version of the EOS 450D.

The 18 – 55 mm autofocus lens that comes with the camera is average. It's not going to be particularly useful when you go out on hiking trips or for wildlife photography. The lens does not provide sufficient zoom for that kind of photography, but for casual photographs portrait and closed ranged photography, it will do.

The buttons are small and the jog dial is a little hard to roll. A single jog dial is used to cycle the settings and a button is used together with the jog dial when combinations are required. All the settings expected from an entry-level dSLR are present. There are no limitations with this camera in terms of features.



Canon EOS 400D

What we looked for while reviewing dSLRs

The cameras were tested for many parameters and factors. We particularly focussed on the usability of the camera and its functionality. dSLRs are advanced cameras meant for the niche customer unlike regular P&Ss.

Although each manufacturer lets you add different lenses to your camera, we used the set supplied to us for testing. Notes were made of the type of lens and we thoroughly tried out the functionality of the lens for both macro shots and telephoto. Portrait photos were also taken to see if there was any distortion when taking relatively close-up shots with the supplied kit lens.

Photographs were taken at extreme ends of the ISO range (100 – 3200) to get an idea of the amount of graininess (noise) that would be visible in the images. A good sensor and processor together would provide less graininess and would be better suited for low-light photography. An overall rating for quality was given by comparing different photographs taken at different ISO settings and aperture settings.

The autofocus functions on these cameras do not work the same way. A range of settings is available to control focus on different types and numbers of objects. We tried each of the settings to see if the camera could focus on smaller objects and also in low light. Cameras have built-in features that use a strobe-like flash to help it focus on objects in the dark. We also tried out the flash to see how much of light the unit would disperse and also to see how well the camera evaluated lighting conditions.

The screens on the dSLRs' display photographic results, and in some of cases is even used to focus. We took note of the quality of the screen and how well they could cope in broad daylight. A larger screen would usually be welcome.

A dSLR is more advanced than a P&S, and gives the user much more control over its features. All features are controlled through its menus and for this reason the user interface is very important. With entry-level dSLRs, manufacturers have tried implementing simpler menus with help for each item.

The quality of the dials on the camera is an important part of the build quality. Changing between settings is done using these buttons and dials, so these controls will take a battering over time. All dSLRs are built solidly to protect the mechanical components, so the chances of things going seriously wrong are pretty low. Still, cost cutting is something every manufacturer tries to do on their lower-end models, and so we kept an eye out for possible problems.

Notes were taken of all the additional features such as noise reduction and synchronising features for the flash. There were many other features – such as the Live View picture which lets you focus and shoot using the LCD screen and also video recording.

Professional photographer and close friend of the magazine, Manas Parekh, came down to personally try out each camera. We were able to get a look at the cameras in a different light with his opinion of each camera that we tested. His inputs are incorporated into the reviews.